1964 – 1975 • THE USA: CONFLICT AT HOME AND ABROAD

THE USA, 1954–1975

Key Topic 4: Reactions to, and the End of, US Involvement in Vietnam (1964 – 1975)



Plate I: Anti-war demonstrators confront armed military police during the March on the Pentagon in Washington D.C. (October 1967).

HISTORICAL OVERVIEW 1964 – 1975

"As graphic television footage beamed uncensored carnage, body bags, and civilian casualties directly into American living rooms, the home front fractured. Discontent over the military draft, student strikes, and moral atrocities like My Lai culminated in the Kent State tragedy, shattering national unity."

"While President Nixon rallied the "Silent Majority" and unleashed ferocious Christmas Bombings to secure "peace with honour", the 1973 Paris Peace Accords merely delayed the inevitable. Follow the dramatic downfall of South Vietnam, culminating in the historic Fall of Saigon."

KEY TOPIC 4 DIRECTORY Christine Counsell Disciplinary Enquiry Programme • 4 Flat Double-Page Spreads FOUR CANONICAL ENQUIRIES

ENQUIRY 4.1 pp. 4–5 Ref [1.1]–[1.4]

The Living Room War, Conscription & Flashpoints of Moral Outrage

PART I Graphic Television Broadcasts & Deepening Draft Resistance
PART II Moral Catastrophe at My Lai & The Kent State Shootings

KEY QUESTION
How did uncensored television coverage, draft inequities, and moral atrocities like My Lai fuel unstoppable domestic anti-war opposition?

ENQUIRY 4.2 pp. 6–7 Ref [2.1]–[2.4]

Support for the War: Nixon's "Silent Majority" & The Blue-Collar Backlash

PART I Cold War Patriotism & Working-Class Resentment of Counterculture
PART II The 1969 Address, The Hard Hat Riot & The 1972 Landslide

KEY QUESTION
Why did millions of working-class and conservative Americans actively support the Vietnam War against student anti-war protesters?

ENQUIRY 4.3 pp. 8–9 Ref [3.1]–[3.4]

Exit with Honour: Secret Paris Diplomacy, Christmas Bombings & 1973 Accords

PART I Kissinger and Le Duc Tho's Secret Paris Breakthrough
PART II Operation Linebacker II, Thieu's Isolation & The Final Accords

KEY QUESTION
How did secret diplomacy in Paris and ferocious aerial bombardment lead to the January 1973 Paris Peace Accords?

ENQUIRY 4.4 pp. 10–11 Ref [4.1]–[4.4]

The Final Collapse: The Spring Offensive, Fall of Saigon & The Vietnam Legacy

PART I The 1975 Spring Offensive & Operation Frequent Wind Evacuation
PART II The Fourfold Synthesis of Failure & The Vietnam Syndrome

KEY QUESTION
Why did South Vietnam collapse so rapidly in 1975, and what were the decisive causes of American defeat?

PEARSON EDEXCEL SPECIFICATION DIRECTORY

OFFICIAL SYLLABUS CONTENT • KEY TOPIC 4: REACTIONS TO, AND THE END OF, US INVOLVEMENT IN VIETNAM

ISSUE 6 VERBATIM

PAPER CODE & TITLE	ASSESSMENT TARIFF	EXAM QUESTIONS
1HI0/33 • Paper 3 Modern Depth Study	**90 Mins • 52 Marks Total (incl. 4 SPaG) • 30% GCSE**	**Section A (Inference 4m, Causation 12m) • Section B (Utility 8m, Verdict 16m+4)**

SUBTOPIC 4.1 pp. 4–5 • Ref [1.1]–[1.4]

Opposition to the war

- Reasons for the growth of opposition, including the student movement, TV and media coverage of the war and the draft system.
- Public reaction to the My Lai Massacre (1968). The trial of Lt. Calley.
- The Kent State University shootings (1970).

SUBTOPIC 4.2 pp. 6–7 • Ref [2.1]–[2.4]

Support for the war

- Reasons for support for the war, including the fear of communism.
- The 'hard hats' and the 'silent majority'.

SUBTOPIC 4.3 pp. 8–9 • Ref [3.1]–[3.4]

The peace process and end of the war

- Reasons for, and key features of, the peace negotiations (1972–73).
- The significance of the Paris Peace Agreement (1973).
- The economic and human costs of the war for the USA.

SUBTOPIC 4.4 pp. 10–11 • Ref [4.1]–[4.4]

Reasons for the failure of the USA in Vietnam

- The strengths of North Vietnam, including the significance of Russian and Chinese support, Vietcong tactics and the Ho Chi Minh Trail.
- The weaknesses of the US armed forces. The failure of US tactics.
- The impact of opposition to the war in the USA.

PEARSON EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION BLUEPRINT & QUESTION TARIFF

52 MARKS TOTAL • 90 MINS • 30% OF GCSE HISTORY

ASSESSMENT OBJECTIVES (TARIFF BREAKDOWN)

AO1 (14m • 27%): Recall, select and deploy accurate historical knowledge.
AO2 (12m • 23%): Explain and analyse causation, consequence and change.
AO3 (8m • 15%): Analyse and evaluate contemporary source utility in historical context.
AO4 (16m • 31%): Analyse, evaluate and judge differing historical interpretations.
SPaG (4m • 4%): Accurate spelling, punctuation, grammar and specialist vocabulary.

PAPER 3 QUESTION ARCHITECTURE (SECTION A & SECTION B)

Section A Q1 (4m • AO3): Source Inference • Two supported inferences from Source A.
Section A Q2 (12m • AO1/AO2): Causation • Explain why [event happened] (3 PEEL paras).
Section B Q3(a) (8m • AO3): Source Utility • How useful are Sources B & C (Content & COP).
Section B Q3(b–c) (8m • AO4): Interpretations • Main difference (4m) and reasons for difference (4m).
Section B Q3(d) (16m+4 • AO4/AO1): Interpretation Evaluation • How far do you agree?

KEY TOPIC 4 MILESTONE SPINE

TEN DEFINING CAUSAL TURNING POINTS • 1964 – 1975

CHRONOLOGICAL HIGHWAY

16 Mar 1968

The My Lai Massacre in Son My Hamlet

Ref [4.1]

Charlie Company slaughters over 500 unarmed Vietnamese civilians; military cover-up exposed by Seymour Hersh in 1969.

3 Nov 1969

Nixon's "Silent Majority" Televised Address

Ref [4.2]

President appeals to conservative Middle America over the heads of protesters, securing a 77% approval rating.

1 Dec 1969

First Selective Service Draft Lottery

Ref [4.1]

First televised military draft lottery since WWII broadcast live, galvanizing collegiate resistance nationwide.

30 Apr 1970

Invasion of Cambodia Announced

Ref [4.1]

Nixon orders US and ARVN ground troops into neutral Cambodia to destroy communist sanctuaries, sparking campus strikes.

4 May 1970

The Kent State Shootings in Ohio

Ref [4.1]

Ohio National Guardsmen fire 67 rounds into unarmed student demonstrators, killing 4 and wounding 9.

8 May 1970

The Hard Hat Riot in Lower Manhattan

Ref [4.2]

Construction workers assault anti-war students near Wall Street; union leaders forge alliance with Nixon administration.

June 1971

Daniel Ellsberg Leaks The Pentagon Papers

Ref [4.1]

Top-secret DoD history published by New York Times, exposing systematic executive deception regarding Vietnam.

18–29 Dec 1972

Operation Linebacker II ("Christmas Bombings")

Ref [4.3]

Eleven days of B-52 carpet bombing of Hanoi and Haiphong forces North Vietnam back to the Paris negotiating table.

27 Jan 1973

Signing of the Paris Peace Accords

Ref [4.3]

US, North Vietnam, South Vietnam, and Vietcong sign ceasefire; mandates withdrawal of all US combat troops within 60 days.

29 Mar 1973

Last American Combat Troops Depart Vietnam

Ref [4.3]

Final US combat forces leave Saigon; 591 American POWs repatriated, leaving 150,000 North Vietnamese troops in South.

7 Nov 1973

Congress Enacts the War Powers Act

Ref [4.3]

Passed over Nixon's veto, law severely limits presidential authority to commit armed forces overseas without approval.

30 Apr 1975

The Fall of Saigon to Communist Forces

Ref [4.4]

PAVN tanks crash through the gates of the Presidential Palace; South Vietnam surrenders unconditionally.

KEY TOPIC 4 • ENQUIRY 1 OF 4

Part I: Graphic Television Broadcasts & Deepening Draft Resistance

The Living Room War, Conscription & Flashpoints of Moral Outrage

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION *How did uncensored television coverage, draft inequities, and moral atrocities like My Lai fuel unstoppable domestic anti-war opposition?*

[1.1]

The "Living Room War" & The Deepening Credibility Gap

The Television Revolution and Uncensored Combat: Vietnam was the first televised war in human history. Every evening, thirty million American households watched graphic colour footage on network news broadcasts: soldiers firing M16s into dense tree lines, wounded infantrymen screaming on stretchers, and body bags being loaded onto helicopters. Unlike World War II, there was no official military censorship. Journalists like Morley Safer accompanied troops into combat; in August 1965, Safer broadcast footage of Marines burning thatched civilian huts with Zippo lighters in the village of Cam Ne, outraging President Johnson.

The Chasm of the Credibility Gap: As casualty tolls climbed past 30,000 dead, public confidence in the federal government collapsed. The Johnson administration repeatedly assured the public that the war was being won, issuing inflated enemy "body counts" and optimistic progress reports. However, journalists on the ground exposed a grim reality of stalemate, confusion, and corruption. This profound divergence between official White House claims and visual television truth created the "credibility gap", permanently eroding public trust in the presidency and the military establishment.

[1.2]

Conscription, Injustice & The Rebellion Against the Draft

A Deeply Discriminatory Draft System: Opposition to the war was intensely concentrated around the military draft (Selective Service). Between 1965 and 1973, over two million young men were conscripted. The draft system was rife with socioeconomic bias: middle-class and wealthy youths secured college deferments, joined the safe National Guard, or obtained sympathetic doctor's notes for minor physical ailments. Consequently, the burden of jungle combat fell disproportionately upon poor, working-class, and minority youths. African Americans made up roughly 11% of the US population but accounted for over 20% of combat deaths in the early war years.

Mass Resistance and the Anti-War Vanguard: In response, draft resistance erupted across the nation. Young men staged mass rallies to publicly burn their draft registration cards, while thousands fled to Canada or Sweden. Heavyweight boxing champion Muhammad Ali refused induction in 1967 on religious and racial grounds, famously declaring: "I ain't got no quarrel with them Vietcong; no Vietcong ever called me nigger." In December 1969, Nixon introduced a televised draft lottery, but rather than placating students, it provoked even broader panic and protest as young men discovered their fate drawn live on national television.

ENQUIRY 4.1 PART II: CLIMAX, TURNING POINTS & CONSEQUENCES *Part II: Moral Catastrophe at My Lai & The Kent State Shootings*

DECISIVE HISTORICAL MECHANISM *Graphic television broadcasts exposed the stark divergence between official claims and battlefield carnage, transforming the anti-war movement from a student fringe into an irresistible national force.*

[1.3]

Moral Catastrophe at My Lai & The Court-Martial of Calley

The Slaughter at Son My (16 March 1968): On the morning of 16 March 1968, Charlie Company of the 11th Infantry Brigade landed in the village of Son My (My Lai hamlet). Angered by heavy booby-trap casualties and briefed that the village was a Vietcong stronghold, soldiers found only unarmed women, children, and elderly men preparing breakfast. Under the direct orders of Lieutenant William Calley, American troops spent four hours systematically slaughtering up to 504 unarmed civilians, herding families into ditches and executing them, raping girls, and slaughtering livestock. The massacre was halted only when helicopter pilot Hugh Thompson landed between the soldiers and villagers, threatening to open fire on his fellow Americans.

Exposure and the Shattering of Moral Authority: Military brass buried reports of the atrocity for twenty months. In November 1969, investigative journalist Seymour Hersh broke the story, accompanied by horrifying photographs taken by army photographer Ronald Haeberle showing corpses piled in ditches. The revelations shattered the cherished myth of American moral exceptionalism. In March 1971, Calley was convicted of premeditated murder and sentenced to life imprisonment, but President Nixon quickly reduced his sentence to three years of house arrest, further outraging the anti-war movement.

[1.4]

The Historical Verdict: Kent State & The Campus Shutdown

The Incursion into Cambodia and the Kent State Tragedy: On 30 April 1970, President Nixon announced that US and ARVN forces were invading neutral Cambodia to destroy North Vietnamese sanctuaries. The announcement sparked massive outrage among students who felt betrayed by Nixon's withdrawal promises. On 4 May 1970, at Kent State University in Ohio, after three days of tense protests and the burning of the campus ROTC building, twenty-eight Ohio National Guardsmen suddenly turned and fired 67 rifle rounds into an unarmed crowd of student demonstrators, killing four students and wounding nine others.

A Nation in Revolt: John Filo's Pulitzer Prize-winning photograph of fourteen-year-old runaway Mary Ann Vecchio screaming over the lifeless body of student Jeffrey Miller became the defining icon of domestic trauma. Ten days later, police opened fire at Jackson State College in Mississippi, killing two Black students. In the aftermath, over four million students staged nationwide strikes, shutting down more than 450 universities and colleges. The anti-war movement had grown from an idealistic fringe into an unstoppable mass movement that made the indefinite continuation of the war politically impossible.

KEY TOPIC 4 • ENQUIRY 2 OF 4

Part I: Cold War Patriotism & Working-Class Resentment of Counterculture

Support for the War: Nixon's "Silent Majority" & The Blue-Collar Backlash

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION *Why did millions of working-class and conservative Americans actively support the Vietnam War against student anti-war protesters?*

[2.1]

The Patriotic Bastion: Anti-Communism & Middle America

The Enduring Power of Cold War Patriotism: Despite the visibility of university protests, a substantial portion of the American public continued to support the war effort throughout the late 1960s and early 1970s. For millions of conservative and middle-class citizens, opposing communism was an unquestioned moral duty rooted in the lessons of World War II and the Korean War. Veterans' organizations like the American Legion and the Veterans of Foreign Wars (VFW) organized patriotic rallies, arguing that American soldiers were fighting to defend freedom against ruthless totalitarian aggression and prevent the Domino Theory from unfolding across Asia.

The Resentment of the Anti-War Counterculture: Pro-war sentiment was fueled as much by cultural animosity as by foreign policy convictions. Working-class Americans who worked long hours in factories and mines deeply resented the student counterculture, viewing anti-war demonstrators as spoiled, unpatriotic, drug-taking elites who took advantage of college draft deferments while working-class sons shed blood in the jungle. Images of radicals waving Vietcong flags and chanting "Ho, Ho, Ho Chi Minh!" were viewed as a direct, treasonous insult to American soldiers dying in combat.

[2.2]

Nixon & The Mobilization of the "Silent Majority"

The Historic Address of 3 November 1969: Recognizing the deep cultural resentment brewing beneath the surface of American society, President Richard Nixon delivered one of the most effective televised speeches in modern political history. Addressing the nation from the Oval Office, Nixon explicitly framed the debate as a struggle between a vocal, radical minority of street demonstrators and the vast, patriotic populace that followed the law, paid taxes, and sent their children to church: *"And so tonight—to you, the great silent majority of my fellow Americans—I ask for your support."*

A Triumphant Domestic Mandate: Nixon's appeal was a political triumph. The White House switchboard was overwhelmed by tens of thousands of supportive telegrams and telephone calls, and Gallup polls recorded a staggering 77% approval rating for Nixon's Vietnam strategy. The concept of the "Silent Majority" became the central organizing weapon of conservative politics, transforming Middle America into a formidable electoral coalition and convincing Nixon that he possessed the domestic political mandate to withdraw ground troops while aggressively expanding aerial bombing.

ENQUIRY 4.2 PART II: CLIMAX, TURNING POINTS & CONSEQUENCES *Part II: The 1969 Address, The Hard Hat Riot & The 1972 Landslide*

DECISIVE HISTORICAL MECHANISM *Nixon mobilized deep-seated cultural and class resentment among Middle Americans who viewed college protesters as privileged draft-dodgers, securing a populist political mandate to prolong the war.*

[2.3]

Blue-Collar Backlash: The Hard Hat Riots of 1970

The Eruption in Lower Manhattan (8 May 1970): Four days after the Kent State shootings, roughly 1,000 anti-war high school and college students gathered near City Hall in Lower Manhattan to hold a solemn memorial vigil for the slain students. Suddenly, an organized brigade of roughly 200 construction workers in yellow hard hats, carrying American flags and heavy metal tools, charged into the unarmed crowd. Shouting patriotic slogans like "USA All the Way!" and "Love It or Leave It!", the workers brutally beat student protesters with wrenches, pipes, and fists while sympathetic city police officers largely looked on.

The Alliance of Labor and the White House: The violence escalated into the "Hard Hat Riot", spilling into Pace University and surrounding streets, leaving over 70 people injured. Far from condemning the assault, blue-collar unions staged massive pro-war parades involving over 100,000 workers through New York City two weeks later. Nixon capitalized immediately on the event, inviting New York union leader Peter Brennan to the White House and appointing him Secretary of Labor. The Hard Hat Riot symbolized a seismic realignment in American politics: working-class union voters, traditionally the backbone of Roosevelt's Democratic coalition, defected to the Republican Party.

[2.4]

The Historical Verdict: The Fractured American Soul

The Landslide of 1972: The political power of the Silent Majority was demonstrated conclusively in the presidential election of November 1972. The Democratic Party nominated Senator George McGovern, a staunch anti-war liberal who campaigned on the promise of immediate troop withdrawal and amnesty for draft evaders. Nixon and the Republicans successfully branded McGovern as the candidate of "Acid, Amnesty, and Abortion", winning an unprecedented 49-state landslide victory with over 60% of the popular vote, carrying every single state except Massachusetts and Washington, D.C.

A Permanently Polarized Nation: While Nixon's victory proved that a decisive majority of Americans supported his search for "peace with honor", the domestic battle over Vietnam left the American nation permanently scarred. The war destroyed the post-World War II bipartisan consensus in foreign policy, unleashed bitter culture wars between cosmopolitan progressives and traditionalist conservatives, and fostered an enduring cynicism toward national institutions that would define American political life for decades to come.

KEY TOPIC 4 • ENQUIRY 3 OF 4

Part I: Kissinger and Le Duc Tho's Secret Paris Breakthrough

Exit with Honour: Secret Paris Diplomacy, Christmas Bombings & 1973 Accords

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION *How did secret diplomacy in Paris and ferocious aerial bombardment lead to the January 1973 Paris Peace Accords?*

[3.1]

Secret Diplomacy in Paris: Kissinger & Le Duc Tho

The Secret Channel (1969–1972): While public peace negotiations dragged on fruitlessly in Paris under the glare of international media, the real diplomatic breakthrough occurred behind closed doors. Beginning in August 1969, National Security Advisor Henry Kissinger conducted clandestine meetings in private Parisian apartments with North Vietnamese Politburo member Le Duc Tho. The negotiations were grueling and hostile: Hanoi insisted that any peace deal must remove South Vietnamese President Nguyen Van Thieu, while Washington demanded the total withdrawal of North Vietnamese combat troops from the South.

The Crucial Concession of October 1972: By the autumn of 1972, both superpowers faced acute exhaustion. North Vietnam had suffered catastrophic casualties during the failed Easter Offensive, while Nixon was under intense congressional pressure to end the war. In October 1972, Kissinger made the fatal concession that broke the deadlock: the United States agreed that 150,000 North Vietnamese regular troops (PAVN) could remain in their positions inside South Vietnam after the American withdrawal. In return, Hanoi agreed that Thieu could temporarily remain in power in Saigon. Kissinger triumphantly announced: "Peace is at hand."

[3.2]

Operation Linebacker II: The Christmas Bombings

Thieu's Refusal and Diplomatic Collapse: When Kissinger presented the draft treaty to President Thieu in Saigon, the South Vietnamese leader burst into tears of fury, correctly recognizing that leaving 150,000 communist troops inside his country was a death sentence for South Vietnam. Thieu demanded 69 substantive revisions to the treaty. Emboldened by American hesitation, Le Duc Tho walked out of the Paris talks in December 1972, accusing Washington of bad faith.

The Christmas Bombings (18–29 December 1972): Furious at Hanoi and determined to force Thieu into compliance, Nixon ordered Operation Linebacker II: the most ferocious aerial assault of the entire war. For eleven days over Christmas, waves of B-52 Stratofortress bombers dropped over 20,000 tons of ordnance on Hanoi and Haiphong, pulverizing rail yards, power stations, and residential districts, causing over 1,600 civilian deaths. While international outrage was deafening, the bombing compelled Hanoi to resume talks, while Nixon privately threatened Thieu that if he did not sign the agreement, the US would sign alone and cut off all aid.

ENQUIRY 4.3 PART II: CLIMAX, TURNING POINTS & CONSEQUENCES

Part II: Operation Linebacker II, Thieu's Isolation & The Final Accords

DECISIVE HISTORICAL MECHANISM *Relentless B-52 bombing forced Hanoi back to the negotiating table, while secret diplomatic concessions allowed North Vietnamese troops to remain in the South, achieving an American exit under the guise of a "decent interval".*

[3.3]

The Paris Peace Accords: The Terms of American Exit

Signing the Accords (27 January 1973): On 27 January 1973, the foreign ministers of the United States, North Vietnam, South Vietnam, and the Vietcong formally signed the Paris Peace Accords at the Hotel Majestic. The treaty mandated an immediate ceasefire in place, the complete withdrawal of all remaining US combat troops and advisors within sixty days, the dismantling of all US military bases, and the repatriation of all prisoners of war (POWs). In exchange, North Vietnam promised to return 591 American POWs and respect the territorial integrity of South Vietnam pending free democratic elections.

The Departure of US Combat Forces: On 29 March 1973, the last American combat troops boarded transport aircraft at Tan Son Nhut airport, bringing direct US military involvement in Vietnam to an official end. For the United States, the nightmare of ground combat had ended; 591 American prisoners, including future senator John McCain, stepped onto American soil to emotional national celebrations. However, the underlying reality was tragic: the treaty left North Vietnam in an overwhelmingly dominant military position inside South Vietnam, with no effective enforcement mechanism.

[3.4]

The Historical Verdict: The Illusion of "A Decent Interval"

The "Decent Interval" Strategy: Declassified White House tapes have since confirmed what historians long suspected: Nixon and Kissinger never believed South Vietnam could survive independently under the terms of the Paris Peace Accords. Their primary strategic goal was to achieve a "decent interval"—a politically acceptable buffer of one or two years between American military withdrawal and Saigon's inevitable collapse—allowing Washington to avoid the catastrophic humiliation of direct military defeat while securing the return of American POWs.

Congress and the Shackling of Presidential Power: Nixon had privately promised Thieu that if North Vietnam violated the ceasefire, the US would respond with overwhelming air strikes. However, this guarantee was completely nullified by domestic events. The burgeoning Watergate scandal destroyed Nixon's political authority, forcing his resignation in August 1974. Furthermore, in November 1973, Congress passed the War Powers Act over Nixon's veto, severely curtailing executive authority to commit troops overseas. When Congress subsequently slashed financial and military aid to Saigon by 50%, South Vietnam was left entirely defenseless.

KEY TOPIC 4 • ENQUIRY 4 OF 4

Part I: The 1975 Spring Offensive & Operation Frequent Wind Evacuation

The Final Collapse: The Spring Offensive, Fall of Saigon & The Vietnam Legacy

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION *Why did South Vietnam collapse so rapidly in 1975, and what were the decisive causes of American defeat?*

[4.1]

The Final Cataclysm: The Spring Offensive of 1975

The Abandonment of South Vietnam: By late 1974, South Vietnam was suffering severe economic and military collapse. The cutoff of American subsidies caused runaway inflation, fuel shortages, and a desperate lack of ammunition; ARVN artillery batteries were rationed to just three shells per gun per day, and transport trucks were immobilized for lack of spare parts. Sensing total American impotence, North Vietnamese military chief General Van Tien Dung planned a multi-year campaign to conquer the South by 1976.

The "Convoy of Tears" (March 1975): In March 1975, PAVN forces launched a massive surprise armored offensive, capturing the strategic Central Highlands city of Ban Me Thuot in just three days. In a catastrophic panic, President Thieu ordered an immediate, disorderly retreat to consolidate forces along the coast. The retreat degenerated into absolute chaos: over 200,000 ARVN soldiers and a million civilian refugees jammed coastal highways under relentless communist artillery fire in the infamous "Convoy of Tears". Within weeks, Hue and Da Nang fell without a fight; the South Vietnamese military had effectively dissolved.

[4.2]

Operation Frequent Wind & The Fall of Saigon (30 April 1975)

The Final Days of Saigon: By late April 1975, eighteen North Vietnamese divisions surrounded the doomed capital of Saigon. President Thieu resigned on 21 April, bitterly denouncing the United States on television for abandoning an ally before fleeing into exile. As communist artillery shells rained down on Tan Son Nhut air base, the US military launched Operation Frequent Wind: the largest helicopter evacuation in history. Over two days, American helicopters evacuated over 7,000 American personnel and vulnerable South Vietnamese from the roof of the US Embassy and CIA safe houses to aircraft carriers offshore.

Tanks at the Independence Palace: On the morning of 30 April 1975, North Vietnamese T-54 tank Number 843 crashed through the wrought-iron ornamental gates of the Presidential Palace in Saigon. A soldier ran to the roof and unfurled the red, blue, and gold flag of the National Liberation Front. Inside, South Vietnam's final president, Duong Van Minh, surrendered unconditionally, stating: "I have been waiting since early morning to transfer the government to you." The victorious North Vietnamese officer replied bluntly: "You cannot transfer what you do not have." The Vietnam War was officially over; Saigon was renamed Ho Chi Minh City.

ENQUIRY 4.4 PART II: CLIMAX, TURNING POINTS & CONSEQUENCES *Part II: The Fourfold Synthesis of Failure & The Vietnam Syndrome*

DECISIVE HISTORICAL MECHANISM *Congressional aid cutoffs and executive paralysis following Watergate stripped South Vietnam of air support, triggering a rapid military collapse and leaving the US deeply scarred by the enduring "Vietnam Syndrome".*

[4.3]

The Fourfold Synthesis of American Defeat

The Inadequacy of Technological Power: The catastrophic failure of the United States in Vietnam was the synthesis of four decisive factors: First, **Vietnamese Revolutionary Nationalism:** The Vietcong and North Vietnamese were fighting an existential anti-colonial war for national survival, inspired by Ho Chi Minh and prepared to sacrifice millions of lives to outlast a foreign invader. Second, **Military and Tactical Inadequacy:** The US military relied on conventional attrition, search and destroy sweeps, and heavy carpet bombing, which alienated the rural peasantry and completely failed to neutralize asymmetric guerrilla tunnel networks and jungle supply trails.

Political Illegitimacy and Domestic Collapse: Third, **The Illegitimacy of the Saigon Regime:** The South Vietnamese government was an artificial American creation, crippled by nepotism, corruption, and military juntas that never commanded popular loyalty. Fourth, **The Collapse of the American Home Front:** The draft, rising casualty counts, graphic uncensored television coverage, and moral atrocities like My Lai destroyed the domestic political will required to sustain an open-ended war, forcing the political establishment to withdraw under intense public opposition.

[4.4]

The Historical Verdict: The Traumatic Legacy of Defeat

The Human and Physical Cost: The Vietnam War exacted an appalling toll. Over 58,220 American soldiers died and more than 300,000 were wounded, with hundreds of thousands suffering from lifelong physical disabilities and Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD). For the Vietnamese people, the catastrophe was apocalyptic: between two and three million Vietnamese civilians and combatants were killed, large swaths of the country were poisoned by Agent Orange, and millions of unexploded cluster munitions contaminated agricultural land for generations.

The "Vietnam Syndrome" and American Foreign Policy: For the United States, the war shattered the myth of American military invincibility and moral righteousness. The trauma produced the "Vietnam Syndrome"—a profound, enduring reluctance among the American public and Congress to intervene in foreign civil conflicts without overwhelming force, clear exit strategies, and guaranteed public support. The heroic era of post-World War II global interventionism had come to a bitter, painful end in the smouldering ruins of Southeast Asia.

MASTER KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL QUIZ

40 ESSENTIAL RECALL QUESTIONS • KEY TOPIC 4: REACTIONS TO, AND THE END OF, US INVOLVEMENT IN VIETNAM

PARTNER QUIZ OR SOLO PRACTICE

CLASSROOM PROTOCOL **Oral Retrieval:** Work with a revision partner to test each card aloud without consulting the reading text. • **Written Synthesis:** Complete questions 1 to 40 in your revision book, referencing the paragraph anchors above each card to verify your answers.

ENQUIRY 4.1 The Living Room War, Conscription & Flashpoints of Moral Outrage

pp. 4–5 • Ref [1.1]–[1.4]

1. What was the name of the system used to select young men for compulsory military service in Vietnam?
2. At which university did National Guardsmen shoot and kill four student protesters in May 1970?
3. Which student organization was at the forefront of the early anti-war protest movement?
4. What symbolic protest method involved young men burning their official government service notices?
5. Which heavyweight boxing champion famously refused to be drafted in 1967, citing religious beliefs?
6. What term describes the difference between what the government reported about the war and what journalists showed on TV?
7. In which South Vietnamese village did US troops massacre over 500 unarmed civilians in March 1968?
8. Who was the US Army lieutenant court-martialed and convicted of murder for ordering the My Lai massacre?
9. What was the name of the top-secret government history of the war leaked to the press in 1971?
10. Which trusted CBS news anchor declared in 1968 that the war was mired in a stalemate?

ENQUIRY 4.2 Support for the War: Nixon's "Silent Majority" & The Blue-Collar Backlash

pp. 6–7 • Ref [2.1]–[2.4]

11. What term did Nixon use in November 1969 to describe the patriotic Americans who supported his war policy?
12. What was the primary political motivation for pro-war supporters in the US, fearing the global spread of communism?
13. What violent event occurred in New York City in May 1970 where construction workers attacked anti-war students?
14. What informal term was used to describe politicians and citizens who supported the escalation of the war?
15. What informal term was used to describe politicians and citizens who favored a peaceful exit from the war?
16. What popular pro-war slogan expressed the view that citizens who criticized the war should emigrate?
17. Which US president made the famous 'Silent Majority' speech on television in November 1969?
18. Which major national labor union coalition supported Nixon's war policy and helped organize the Hard Hat Riots?
19. What was the main purpose of President Nixon's 'Silent Majority' speech in 1969?
20. What pro-war student organization was formed to counter the radical anti-war Student Mobilization Committee?

ENQUIRY 4.3 Exit with Honour: Secret Paris Diplomacy, Christmas Bombings & 1973 Accords

pp. 8–9 • Ref [3.1]–[3.4]

21. What event marked the official end of the Vietnam War and the defeat of South Vietnam in 1975?
22. What was the name of the final North Vietnamese conventional offensive that captured Saigon in 1975?
23. What was the name of the US helicopter evacuation of Saigon in April 1975?
24. Who was the South Vietnamese President who surrendered Saigon to North Vietnamese forces?
25. Which US president was responsible for negotiating and signing the 1973 Paris Peace Accords?
26. How many days did the US have to withdraw all troops under the 1973 Accords?
27. Why did South Vietnamese President Thieu initially refuse to sign the accords?
28. What bombing campaign was ordered to force the signing of the accords in late 1972?
29. Which 1973 Act of Congress limited the president's power to commit troops to foreign conflicts without approval?
30. Which constitutional amendment lowered the US voting age to 18 in 1971, prompted by the draft?

ENQUIRY 4.4 The Final Collapse: The Spring Offensive, Fall of Saigon & The Vietnam Legacy

pp. 10–11 • Ref [4.1]–[4.4]

31. What was the name of the highly resilient supply route running through Laos and Cambodia that the US failed to block?
32. Which two communist superpowers provided essential military hardware, air defenses, and financial aid to North Vietnam?
33. What term was used to describe the collapse of morale behavior where US soldiers intentionally killed their own officers with grenades?
34. What US military strategy of attrition failed because the Vietcong were fighting a total war and could replace losses indefinitely?
35. What was a major cause of low morale and drug abuse among US troops, who were mostly young, working-class conscripts?
36. What chemical weapons and defoliants dropped by the US ruined its global reputation and alienated South Vietnamese peasants?
37. Which 1968 offensive, though a military defeat for the Vietcong, was a political victory that shattered US support?
38. What did the US Congress cut in 1974 that severely weakened the South Vietnamese military prior to the final invasion?
39. What term describes the psychological reluctance of the US public and politicians to intervene militarily abroad after Vietnam?
40. What was the primary economic consequence of the war's high military expenditure on the US homefront?